In his book, **Chaos: Charles Manson, the CIA, and the Secret History of the Sixties** (2019), investigative journalist **Tom O'Neill** uses the Haight-Ashbury Free Medical Clinic (HAFMC) as a central piece of evidence to challenge the official "Helter Skelter" narrative of the Manson murders.

The Role of the Haight-Ashbury Free Medical Clinic:
O'Neill identifies the clinic, founded by **Dr. David Smith**, as a critical hub where Charles Manson's path intersected with potential government-funded mind-control research in the late 1960s.

- **Manson's Presence:** Manson and his "Family" were frequent visitors to the HAFMC. While his female followers were often treated for STDs and malnutrition, Manson met there weekly with his parole officer, **Roger Smith**.
- **The "Jolly" West Connection:** O'Neill highlights that **Dr. Louis Jolyon "Jolly" West**, a psychiatrist with deep ties to the CIA's **MKUltra** program, conducted research at the clinic. West established what he called a "laboratory disguised as a hippie crash pad" to study the effects of LSD on youth culture.
- **Behavioral Modification:** O'Neill posits that Manson may have been an unwitting subject of, or influenced by, West's research. He suggests Manson's ability to "brainwash" his followers in less than a year mirrored the specific goals of MKUltra: using LSD and psychological techniques to create "programmed" individuals.

Summary of *Chaos* Key Themes:
The book argues that the official story of the Manson murders—propounded by prosecutor Vincent Bugliosi—is incomplete and potentially covers up deeper institutional failures or conspiracies.

- **Official Narrative Gaps:** O'Neill questions why Manson was granted extreme leniency for numerous parole violations and why law enforcement failed to act on clear warning signs before the 1969 Tate-LaBianca murders.
- **Operation CHAOS:** The book's title refers to the CIA's domestic surveillance program, **Operation CHAOS**, which aimed to disrupt the 1960s counterculture. O'Neill explores whether Manson was utilized as a tool to delegitimize the hippie movement by associating it with extreme violence.
- **The "Manchurian Candidate" Theory:** While admitting he found no "smoking gun" to prove Manson was a direct CIA asset, O'Neill presents extensive circumstantial evidence suggesting Manson's methods of control were remarkably similar to those being refined by government researchers in the Haight-Ashbury district at the same time.